Generating options

How do we generate genuinely different options without jumping to the first attractive idea?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Generated at least three distinct options and a do-minimum baseline from a journey map of the affected group.

- Map the affected group's journey using published evidence.
- Frame How Might We questions at the points where the journey breaks.
- Generate options that differ in mechanism, at different orders of change.
- Screen options quickly on impact and effort, without choosing yet.

Competencies: G1 · G2 · C4

Session plan

10 min	**Opening problem**
20 min	**Concept: options, not solutions**
20 min	**Demonstration: Madhyapur options**
35 min	**Activity: policy innovation lab**
25 min	**Own case: options canvas**
10 min	**Debrief and exit task**

Opening problem

- **Name the first solution that comes to mind for your case. Now name two that work through a completely different mechanism.**

If the second and third are versions of the first, you have one option, not three.

A journey map: a Madhyapur household

1	2	3	4	5
Generate	**Store**	**Hand over**	**Observe**	**Conclude**
Waste piles up in one kitchen bin; no space for a second.	Dry waste kept in a bag on the balcony, if at all.	The crew arrives at an unpredictable time; one bag is handed over.	The crew tips everything into one compartment.	Separating seems pointless; the household stops.

Mark where the journey breaks: each break is a place an option could act. Without fieldwork, build the map from published accounts and studies.

How Might We: turning breaks into questions

Break in the journey	How might we...
No space for a second bin	...make separate storage easy in small homes?
Unpredictable collection	...make collection reliable enough to plan around?
Crews mix the streams	...make keeping streams apart the easiest thing for crews to do?
Households see the mixing	...show households that their separated waste is handled separately?

A good How Might We question names neither the solution nor the whole problem.

Options at three orders of change

1

Adjust settings

Change how existing tools are used. Madhyapur: more frequent campaigns; a stricter enforcement schedule.

2

Change instruments

Use a different tool. Madhyapur: pay for separated tonnes; partner with a waste pickers' cooperative for dry waste.

3

Change goals

Rethink the aim. Madhyapur: from collecting waste to recovering resources, with ward-level processing.

A strong set of options usually includes at least one change of instrument.

Madhyapur: three options and a baseline

Option	Mechanism	Order of change
Baseline: do minimum	Continue the current contract and periodic campaigns	None
A. Pay for separated collection	Renegotiate the contract to pay per separated tonne, with two-compartment vehicles	Instrument
B. Partner with waste pickers	Contract a pickers' cooperative to collect and sort dry waste, with ward sorting centres	Instrument
C. Ward enforcement drive	Monitoring, user charges and penalties, ward by ward, with campaigns	Settings

The options differ in mechanism, not just in scale. Whether to combine them is a Day 17 question.

A quick screen, not a decision: impact and effort



The impact-effort matrix and ICE scoring (impact, confidence, ease) are screening tools. They rank interventions roughly and do not replace tomorrow's appraisal.

Desirability, feasibility, viability

1

Desirable

Would the affected people want it, and use it?

2

Feasible

Can it be done with the capability and technology available?

3

Viable

Can it be sustained, financially and institutionally?

This lens comes from IDEO's design practice. Public policy adds a test tomorrow: legitimacy and support.

A thinker for your case

Peter Hall

"Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State", Comparative Politics, 1993

Hall distinguished first-order change (adjusting the settings of existing instruments), second-order change (new instruments) and third-order change (new goals and ways of seeing the problem).

The question it puts to your case

Are you adjusting settings, changing instruments or changing goals?

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

Activity: Policy innovation lab

Generate a wide set of genuinely different options for a common case before choosing any.

Scenario

People in remote villages of a stylised hill district travel long distances to reach a functioning primary health centre, and many delay care until they are seriously ill. Generate options for the district health officer.

What to do

1. Map the patient's journey from first symptom to treatment, using the case card.
2. Mark three breaks and write a How Might We question for each.
3. Generate at least eight ideas in ten minutes, without judging.
4. Group them into three options that differ in mechanism, plus a baseline.
5. Run a quick impact and effort screen. Do not choose yet.

Time 35 minutes

Groups Pods of four

Output Three distinct options and a baseline, screened

Your case: Worksheet 7.1

Options canvas

1. Map your affected group's journey from published evidence and mark where it breaks.
2. Write a How Might We question for each break.
3. Generate at least eight ideas, then group them into three options that differ in mechanism.
4. Add a do-minimum baseline.
5. Label each option's order of change and run a quick impact and effort screen.

Hand in

Worksheet 7.1 by the start of Day 17.

Quality check

The journey is built from published evidence.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. Generate before you judge; choose tomorrow.
2. Build options from the breaks in the affected group's journey.
3. Three options must differ in mechanism, not just in scale.
4. Include a do-minimum baseline: every option is compared against it.

Exit task Write your three options as three different mechanisms, in five words each.

Before the next session

Independent work

For each option, find one published example of something similar being tried, in India or elsewhere, and note what happened. About 50 minutes.

Read

Brown, Tim. "Design Thinking." Harvard Business Review, June 2008.

Next

Day 17: Choosing between options

Tomorrow you compare the options against explicit criteria, and choose.